LA CHIMERA

Alice Rohrwacher | Visual & Narrative Production Design Critique



SCOPE

Material Culture, Spatial Politics, and Mythic Architecture Across the Complete Film

KEY CONFLICT

Ancient Sacred Earth vs. 1980s Commercial Encroachment and Mythic Longing

ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK: THE SEVEN LENSES

Methodological Approach

1. Colour:

2. Texture:

3. Architecture:

4. Location:

5. Costume:

6. Props:

7. Narrative Tools:

LENS 1: COLOUR — TRIADIC SCHEME

Atmospheric Tonality & Spatial Demarcation

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- **Triadic Foundation:** The core palette is anchored in a primary Triadic scheme of Red, Blue, and Green, providing the foundational chromatic structure for the film's production design.
- **Environmental Tones:** Saturated Greens and deep Blues define the Italian landscapes, grounding the atmospheric tonality in naturalistic, earthy environments.
- **Spatial Demarcation:** A persistent Blue–Red contrast is utilized for frame segmentation, creating visual boundaries between distinct narrative and physical spaces.
- **Commercial Yellow:** Restricted exclusively to Spartaco, Yellow serves as a chromatic signifier for commercial wealth and the encroachment of modern market forces.
- **Arthur's Isolation:** Represented in Neutral White, Arthur's presence serves as a visual vacuum, emphasizing his existential isolation and disconnect from the world around him.



LENS 1: COLOUR — VISUAL CASE STUDIES

Key Color Contrasts



CASE 1. THE SCARLET RED YARN (ARTHUR'S DREAM)



CASE 2. ARTHURS WHITE



CASE 3. DUSTY PASTELS (FLORA'S DAUGHTERS)



CASE 4. SPARTACO'S YELLOW RECEIVING OFFICE

LENS 2: TEXTURE — MATERIAL CONTINUITY & DUAL MATERIALITY

Pervasive Tactility Across Surfaces

- **Lived-In Aesthetic:** The film prioritizes surfaces defined by age and abrasion, where material history is rendered visible through physical wear.
- **Anti-Pristine Staging:** Deliberate accumulation of dust and mud rejects commercial "cleanliness," grounding the narrative in the soil of the past.
- **The Trauma of the Severed Neck:** A violent juxtaposition between the smooth, sacred glaze of ancient terracotta and the jagged, clinical violence of modern saw marks.
- **Tactile Warmth:** In contrast to the cold clay of the tombs, the commune utilizes soft textiles and raw wool to represent living, breathing materiality.





LENS 2: TEXTURE — VISUAL CASE STUDIES

PHYSICAL WEAR & MATERIAL RUPTURE



FIG 1. ARTHUR'S SPLITTING LEATHER SHOE (CRACKED, DUSTY)



FIG 2. MATERIALS OF THE SHACK (CORRUGATED METAL, SPLINTERED WOOD)



FIG 3. PEELING PLASTER (VILLA PALOMBINA FRESCOES)



FIG 4. THE CITYSCAPE

LENS 3: ARCHITECTURE — VISUAL CASE STUDIES

The 5 Spaces in Frame



FIG 1. ARTHUR'S SHACK (ON MEDIEVAL WALLS)

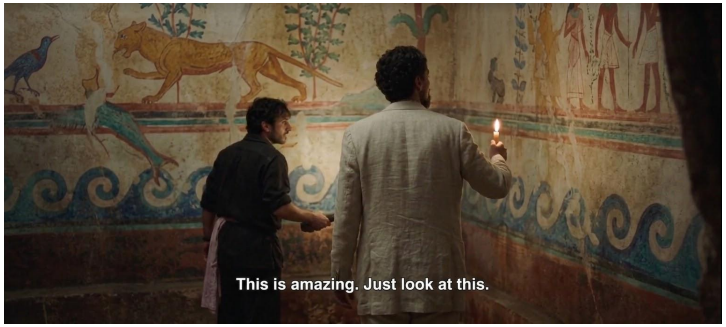


FIG 2. SUBTERRANEAN ETRUSCAN DROMOS



FIG 3. THE PRISTINE YACHT DECK `



FIG 4. THE CITY

LENS 3: ARCHITECTURE — SPACE PLANNING IN THE ABANDONED STATION

Adaptive Reuse & The Sanctuary of Fostered Care

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LENS 4: LOCATION / SETTING — AGRARIAN ROOTS & INDUSTRIAL BORDERS

Topography of Ancient Etruria & The Offshore Void

- **Agrarian landscape:** The setting is defined by unpaved paths and sprawling pastures, grounding the narrative in the physical memory of Etrurian soil.
- **Peripheral technology:** Modern industrial elements like power plants and tractors exist on the margins, signaling the encroachment of a new era.
- **Spatial contrast:** A stark spatial divide between the Empty house and Arthur's Shack
- **Structural friction:** The composition captures the visual conflict between ancient agrarian roots and the encroaching industrial void.





LENS 4: LOCATION / SETTING — VISUAL CASE STUDIES

Landscapes of the Sacred and the Industrial



FIG 1. TRAIN STATION



FIG 2. WINDSWEPT HILLTOP DIG SITE



FIG 3.THE YATCH



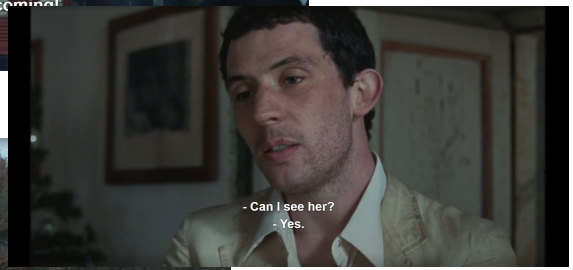
FIG 4. INDUSTRIAL COASTLINE

LENS 5: COSTUME — FLORA'S BLACK, PASTEL SISTERS & ARTHUR'S GHOST

Wardrobe Economy, Class Coding, and Spectral Dissolution

- **Flora:** Presentation of mourning black as a performative signifier of lost aristocracy, with the turquoise socks serving as a jarring material exception.
- **The Sisters:** Dressed in dusty, desaturated pastels (mauve, peach) representing a domestic, stagnant femininity that contrasts the outdoor ruggedness of the gang.
- **Arthur:** The rumpled cream linen suit functions as a "bourgeois ghost" costume; it is an artifact of a higher class decaying in real-time against the earth.
- **The Tombaroli:** Uniformed in functional 70s workwear—heavy wools and denim—rooting them in the material labor of the "grab."
- **Spartaco:** Use of the 80s power silhouette with padded shoulders and a sharp YELLOW accent to signal predatory commercialism.







LENS 5: COSTUME — VISUAL CASE STUDIES

Attire as Social and Existential Armor



CASE STUDY 1: FLORA IN MOURNING BLACK



CASE STUDY 2: DAUGHTERS IN PASTEL KNITS



CASE STUDY 3: ITALIA'S DOMESTIC SMOCK



CASE STUDY 4: SPARTACO'S YELLOW AUCTION ENSEMBLE

LENS 6: PROPS — 'OBJECTS WITH AN INVISIBLE PART'

Utilitarian Digging Tools vs. The Violation of the Sacred

- **Digging Gear:** Steel probes and spades function as the cold, utilitarian instruments of the *tombaroli*, stripping the earth of mystery through physical force.
- **Commodity vs. Sacred:** The central prop conflict—ancient relics intended for eternity are reduced to market commodities via transaction.
- **Desacralization:** The use of crude plastic bags and burlap sacks highlights the aesthetic violation of sacred objects during their 'modern' handling.
- **The Catalyst:** The Severed Goddess head serves as the ultimate prop; its physical displacement initiates Arthur's final descent into the shadow world.
- **Ariadne's Clew:** The **Red Thread** acts as a visual lifeline, a prop that literally and metaphorically bridges the gap between the living and the dead.





LENS 6: PROPS — VISUAL CASE STUDIES

The Sacred, The Profane, and The Rescued



FIG 1. SACRED FRAGMENTS: SHELVES OF POTSHERDS IN SHACK



FIG 2. ARTEFACTS FOR SPARTACUS



FIG 3. DISPLACED DIVINITY: GODDESS HEAD HELD ON YACHT



FIG 4. THE RESCUED LIGHT: FINAL SULFUR MATCHES IN CAVE-IN

LENS 7: NARRATIVE TOOLS — FILM ARCHAEOLOGY & THE INVERTED FRAME

Multi-Format Stocks, The 180° Roll, and Ontological Inversion







LENS 7: NARRATIVE TOOLS — THE EXTRADIEGETIC FOLK CHORUS

Cantastorie, Oral Ballads, and The Mythic Plane

- **Ontological Liminality:** Musicians who do not exist within the material reality of the characters, acting as ghosts of the narrative itself.
- **The Cantastorie Tradition:** A direct invocation of the Italian ballad singer tradition, where oral history is performed for the public square.
- **Temporal Framing:** Singing events in the past tense frames Arthur's lived experience as an already-completed mythic cycle.
- **Brechtian Rupture:** Frequent fourth-wall breaks remind the audience of the film's constructed nature, creating a distancing effect for analytical critique.
- **Mythic vs. Material:** The chorus serves as the gateway to the mythic plane, contrasting the spiritual weight of antiquity with 1980s commercialism.



NARRATIVE STRUCTURE: PARALLEL FORCES (ARTHUR VS. ITALIA)

The Dual Trajectories of Death and Life

- **The Vertical Axis:** Arthur's subterranean descent into the buried and dead vs. Italia's surface vitality rooted in the collective community of the living.
- **Rejection of Surface Salvation:** Arthur's refusal of the potential for a standardized domestic life above ground, favoring the pull of the "chimera" or the mythic lost object.
- **Fable Distance over Melodrama:** The narrative prioritizes the detached rigor of a fable, maintaining a structural distance that avoids emotional manipulation in favor of cinematic philosophy.
- **Key Takeaway:** Arthur's ultimate destiny is not found in the daylight of the present, but remains irrevocably tied to the realm of shadows and antiquity.

> *"The tragedy of La Chimera is that Arthur cannot accept the living world; his destiny is irrevocably tied to the realm of shadows."*
>
> — NARRATIVE STRUCTURE ANALYSIS

Narrative Circularity: The Red Thread & The Merged Ending

The Beginning of the End & The Closed Mythic Loop

- **Transit as Liminal Passage:** The train functions as Charon's Ferry, a recurring structural vessel that transports the protagonist between the material world and the subterranean realm of shadows.
- **Dream-Destination Convergence:** Narrative circularity is achieved by equating the opening flashback dream with the final destination; the film's start is the literal entry point of the end.
- **Subterranean Manifestation:** The physical collapse of the tomb acts as the catalyst for the red thread's manifestation—a visible umbilical cord connecting Arthur to his lost ideal.
- **Mythic Archetypal Merging:** The production design collapses the distance between the Ariadne and Orpheus myths, where the search for the beloved and the escape from the labyrinth become a singular, merged action.
- **Temporal Collapse:** The final frame enforces a state of total narrative unity where the chronological beginning and the mythic end are revealed to be one and the same.

CONCLUSION: MATERIALITY AS STORYTELLING

Production Design as Cinematic Philosophy

- **The Core Paradox:** The internal conflict of the narrative is defined by sacred beauty lost via the relentless force of commodification.
- **Tactile World-Building:** Rohrwacher establishes a grounded, sensory reality through physical artifacts such as worn shoes and dusty linen.
- **Intimate Narrative:** An epic story of cultural loss is meticulously articulated through the smallest details—frayed seams, ceramic shards, and loose thread.
- **Materiality as Conduit:** The physical substance of the film serves as cinema's most potent conduit for philosophical inquiry and mythic resonance.